

Five Evenings at the Table

Before we stand up: reading, given circumstances, character and scene work for Six Characters in Search of an Author · Village Players, Lausanne · dir. Kiarash Jamshidi
Thursdays 2 · 9 · 16 · 23 · 30 July 2026 · 18:00–21:00 · SSA Lausanne

Table work is the part of rehearsal where we sit and read, before anyone stands up. We read the play aloud, agree what is actually happening in each scene, and find what every character wants — so the August staging has something solid to build on.

These five Thursday evenings take the play one act at a time, then join it up. The rule throughout: we read to discover, not to perform. The performances come later, on the floor.

The five evenings at a glance

THURSDAY 2 JULY 2026 Act One at the table Settle in calmly: agree the ground rules, read Act One flat and then over-the-top, talk about what jumped out, and take a short plain look at the world of the play.	THURSDAY 9 JULY 2026 Act Two at the table Read Act Two flat and over-the-top, find why the comedy after Madame Pace has to be nervous, and place the Mother's quiet keystone line.	THURSDAY 16 JULY 2026 Act Three at the table Read Act Three flat and over-the-top, find the line between real feeling and cold argument, and protect the quiet around the two deaths.	THURSDAY 23 JULY 2026 The whole play, joined up Read the play as one connected thing, in words only: relationships across the arc, the layers, the tempo, the nervous comedy, and the safety agreement confirmed.	THURSDAY 30 JULY 2026 The full cue-called read, and hand-off to August Read the whole play through with the Stage Manager calling cues and the pianist marking tempo, then hand off cleanly to the August staging block.
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How we run the room

GROUND RULES

- We read to discover, not to correct. Nobody locks in a fixed "take" on a character or a line this early.
- We stay seated all five evenings. No moving, no blocking, no physical or intimacy work at the table. The big "over-the-top" read pushes the voice only, never touch.
- The charged moments (the veil, the shop scene, the deaths) are talked about in words only. We set them as safe, agreed choreography in August, never improvised.
- Read first, talk second. The director asks what you found before offering an interpretation.
- Anyone can say "hold" at any moment, for any reason, no explanation needed. We agree this word on night one.
- Don't over-talk it. Every extra minute of table chat is a staging minute lost. Share the facts and the questions, then we get up in August.

BRING TO EVERY SESSION

- Your own script — every actor brings their own copy to every session (the company doesn't hand out scripts). Bring it each week.
- A pencil and a simple two-column sheet: Facts on one side, Questions on the other.
- A one-page character sheet: Who am I? What just happened? My relationships? What do I want? What's in my way? What do I do about it?
- A short list of strong verbs for actioning (one verb per line: what am I doing to the other person? — e.g. shock, reassure, tease, threaten).

WHO DOES WHAT

- Director (Kiarash Jamshidi) — leads each evening, runs the two readings and the chats after, and keeps the tone honest: funny and painful at once.
- Assistant Director — the director's second pair of eyes. Keeps the notes on what the room decides, flags when the tone or energy slips, and briefs anyone who missed a night.
- Stage Manager — runs the logistics: the room, attendance, and the prompt book (every decision now, every cue later). Reads the stage directions aloud, keeps time, and calls the cues on night five.
- Everyone — read aloud, join both readings, fill in your homework sheet, and speak up. Quiet roles get asked the same questions as the leads.

SHAPE OF AN EVENING

Each evening runs 18:00 to 21:00 at SSA Lausanne, everyone seated, with a real break in the middle and a short second break later. We start with a quick and a gentle vocal warm-up, do the main reading and work, then a fast go-round so everyone speaks, set homework, and finish with a short.

REMEMBER Table work serves the floor — we read to discover, not to perform, and we get up the moment talk stops earning its keep.

How we work at the table

The two-pass read: flat first, over-the-top second. Open each act by reading its key scenes twice — first completely flat (no emotion, just the words), then deliberately over-the-top — and then talk about what each read showed.

Read to discover, then get up. Read a scene before we discuss it, and do only as much talking as we need — then we get up in August.

Funny and painful in the same breath. Never pure farce (the wounds turn to jokes) or cold philosophy (the feeling goes dead): the audience should laugh, then wish they hadn't.

Know which of the four layers you're in. Always know which of the play's four layers you are in: (1) the company at rehearsal, (2) the six Characters, (3) their story, (4) the actors trying to play them.

Aim outward, not inward. For each line, name what you want from the other person and one strong verb to get it — feeling comes out of doing.

The Sessions

SESSION 1 Thursday 2 July 2026

Act One at the table

Settle in calmly: agree the ground rules, read Act One flat and then over-the-top, talk about what jumped out, and take a short plain look at the world of the play.

GOALS FOR THE EVENING

- Understand what each of the six wants the moment they walk in — and why none of them can simply leave.
- Find the Father's hunger to be understood and to keep control of the story, and catch the first cracks where it slips.
- Hear the Step-Daughter as the engine of the act: she wants the truth shown, not made beautiful — and feel “Valentine” as a wound, not a turn.
- Watch the Manager get pulled from “throw them out” to “there may be a play here,” and weigh what he agrees to — and risks — in the bargain.

THE EVENING, HOUR BY HOUR

18:00

Welcome

Welcome the company. Name tags for anyone new.

18:10

Warm-up

A gentle seated voice and breath warm-up.

18:20

Ground rules and the “hold” word

Agree the time-out word “hold”: anyone can stop the room at any moment, no reason needed. Quick and light.

18:35

World of the play — and the four layers

A short, plain talk before we read: who the family and the company are, and the play's four layers — the

company; the Characters; their story; the actors who later try to play them — so everyone knows which layer they're in.

18:50

Part I — The Rehearsal

Read it flat, then put the Part I questions below. (See “Part by part”.)

19:05

Part II — The Interruption

Read it flat, then the Part II questions. (The six walk in.)

19:22

Part III — The Bargain

Read it flat, then the Part III questions.

19:35

Break (15 min)

Water, tea, food. Rest your voice.

19:50

Act One, over-the-top

Read the whole act way too big — full melodrama, no holding back.

20:30

What jumped out

Where it got funny, dangerous or raw — and where “Valentine” stops being just a song.

20:45

Homework and close

Set homework and confirm next week is Act Two.

PART BY PART — READ IT FLAT, THEN ASK

After the flat read of each part, put these questions to the characters who appear in it. One sentence each, in role — then move on.

18:50–19:05 Part I — The Rehearsal

In it: The Manager, Player 1, Player 2, Player 3

The Manager

- What kind of day are you having before they walk in?
- What do you really think of the play you're forced to rehearse?
- What would make tonight a good night for you?

Player 1

- What do you think you're owed in this company?
- What was the best role you ever played — and how long ago?
- What are you afraid the others see when they look at you?

Player 2

- What keeps you patient with all of them?
- What do you do here that nobody thanks you for?
- What would you rather be doing?

Player 3

- What are you still excited about?
- What do you want to learn from the older two?
- What don't you understand about this job yet?

19:05–19:22 Part II — The Interruption

In it: The Father, The Step-Daughter, The Mother, The Son, The Manager

The Father

- What do you need them to believe?
- Which story do you most want told — and why now?
- What are you ashamed of that you'll talk around?
- When you look at the Step-Daughter, what do you feel?

The Step-Daughter

- What do you want them to see that the Father won't say?
- What has he done to you?
- Why is being 'made pretty' worse than being ignored?
- What do you want to happen to him tonight?

The Mother

- What are you trying to stop from happening?
- Who are you most afraid for?
- Why can't you speak the way the others do?

The Son

- Why don't you want to be here?
- What were you promised as a child that you never got?
- What would you do if you could just walk out?

The Manager

- When do you stop wanting to throw them out?
- What first makes you curious instead of angry?
- What do you risk if you listen to them?

19:22–19:35 Part III — The Bargain

In it: The Father, The Manager, The Step-Daughter

The Father

- What are you offering him — and what are you hiding?
- What can a stage give you that nothing else can?
- What happens to you if he says no?

The Manager

- What finally makes you say yes?
- What do you tell yourself to justify it?
- What are you already imagining the audience will think?

The Step-Daughter

- What are you afraid they'll make pretty?
- Which part of the story must they keep, no matter what?
- What do you want out of being watched?

HOMEWORK Fill in your character sheet for your Act One scene and start learning your Act One lines.

BY THE END We've agreed the ground rules, shared a clear picture of the play, and heard Act One both ways with "Valentine" tested as a wound.

Act Two at the table

Read Act Two flat and over-the-top, find why the comedy after Madame Pace has to be nervous, and place the Mother's quiet keystone line.

GOALS FOR THE EVENING

- Understand the real subject of the act: a theatre trying to build a true wound out of props and stand-ins — and failing.
- Find the Step-Daughter alone in the shower light: her tenderness for the child and her fury at the men, in the same breath.
- Build Madame Pace so the room laughs at her and then cannot — and pin down the exact line where the laugh dies.
- Feel why watching actors replay your worst hour is unbearable, and land the Mother's “It's taking place now.”

THE EVENING, HOUR BY HOUR

18:00	Warm-up A seated voice warm-up. The pianist is here tonight.
18:15	Part I — The Setup Read it flat, then the Part I questions. Includes the Step-Daughter's shower speech.
18:32	Part II — The Apparition Read it flat, then the Part II questions. Madame Pace arrives.
18:52	Part III — The Substitution Read it flat, then the Part III questions. The actors replay the scene.
19:07	Break (15 min) Rest your voice. Water and food.
19:22	Act Two, over-the-top — the comedy test Read it too big and overplay the comedy after Pace — feel exactly where the laugh has to curdle.
20:00	Madame Pace and the curdle point Funny accent on arrival, full menace by the end. Mark where the room must stop laughing.
20:25	The music and the Mother's keystone Pianist marks the Satie and the cabaret vamp; place “It's taking place now.”
20:45	Go-round and close Everyone names one thing they found, then we set homework.

PART BY PART — READ IT FLAT, THEN ASK

After the flat read of each part, put these questions to the characters who appear in it. One sentence each, in role — then move on.

18:15–18:32 Part I — The Setup

In it: The Step-Daughter, The Manager, The Mother, The Son

The Step-Daughter

- In the shower speech, who are you really talking to?
- What do you feel for the little one — and for the boy?
- Why does getting the room exactly right matter so much?
- What do you wish you could undo?

The Manager

- What are you actually building out of these props?
- What excites you about this scene as theatre?
- What won't you let yourself feel about it?

The Mother

- What do you dread is coming?
- What do you want to say to your daughter and can't?
- What keeps you in the room when you want to run?

The Son

- What are you watching from the edge?
 - What will you not be part of, and why?
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18:32–18:52 Part II — The Apparition

In it: Madame Pace, The Step-Daughter, The Father, The Mother

Madame Pace

- What are you really selling?
- How do you see the girls who come to you?
- What makes you good at this — and how do you sleep at night?
- What do you want from the mother?

The Step-Daughter

- What is it like to watch this happen again?
- What did you feel walking into that room the first time?
- What do you want the Father to understand as he comes near?

The Father

- What do you tell yourself so you can walk into that shop?
- What do you see when you look at her there?
- When do you realise who she is — and what happens in you?

The Mother

- What finally breaks your silence?
- What have you known and refused to know?
- What do you want to do to Madame Pace?

18:52–19:07 Part III — The Substitution

In it: Player 1, Player 2, The Step-Daughter, The Mother

Player 1

- How do you think the scene is going?
- What do you believe good acting is?
- What do you fail to notice about the real man beside you?

Player 2

- What do you get wrong without knowing it?
- What are you proud of in your performance?
- What would it take for you to really see her?

The Step-Daughter

- What's unbearable about watching them play you?
- What do they turn your pain into?
- What do you want to shout at them?

The Mother

- What does 'It's taking place now' mean to you?
- Why can this never be a rehearsal for you?
- What is happening in your body as you say it?

HOMEWORK Bring a character sheet for your Act Two scene; Madame Pace, know the lines cold; Mother, rehearse "It's taking place now" aloud.

BY THE END We've heard Act Two both ways, agreed the comedy must be nervous, built Madame Pace, heard the music, and protected the Mother's quiet line.

Act Three at the table

Read Act Three flat and over-the-top, find the line between real feeling and cold argument, and protect the quiet around the two deaths.

GOALS FOR THE EVENING

- Take the reality/illusion argument as a man fighting for his life, not winning a debate — and find the Step-Daughter's cuts that puncture it.
- Reach the Son's refusal and the single cry that escapes him on the word “horrible.”
- Get to the fountain so the two deaths land in stillness, not volume — and protect the silence after the shot and the Mother's empty arms.
- Hear the Manager turn from running the room to walking out of it, and name what the ending leaves the audience holding.

THE EVENING, HOUR BY HOUR

18:00	Warm-up A seated voice warm-up.
18:15	Part I — The Trap Read it flat, then the Part I questions. The reality/illusion argument.
18:32	Part II — The Refusal Read it flat, then the Part II questions. The Son will not act.
18:50	Part III — The Fountain Read it flat, then the Part III questions. The two deaths.
19:05	Break (15 min) Rest your voice — this is the heaviest act.
19:20	Act Three, over-the-top — feeling vs argument Read it too big, overshoot both raw feeling and cold philosophy, then find the line between them.
19:55	The Father's argument and the Son's cry Score the Father control → horror as panic, not lecture; let the Son's cry land on “horrible.”
20:20	The fountain, in words only Read the ending for stillness, not volume; talk the staged moments through — no contact at the table.
20:45	Go-round and close Everyone names their Act Three aim in one line, then we set homework.

PART BY PART — READ IT FLAT, THEN ASK

After the flat read of each part, put these questions to the characters who appear in it. One sentence each, in role — then move on.

18:15–18:32 **Part I — The Trap**

In it: The Father, The Step-Daughter, The Manager, The Mother

The Father

- What are you really arguing for when you talk about what's real?
- What are you most afraid is true about you?
- Who are you trying to convince — them, or yourself?

The Step-Daughter

- When do you cut him off — and why then?
- What does his philosophy do to your story?
- What do you know about him that he won't admit?

The Manager

- When does this stop being a game to you?
- What unsettles you in what the Father says?
- What do you still want to get done tonight?

The Mother

- What are you holding onto?
- What do the two children mean to you right now?
- What do you understand that the clever ones don't?

18:32–18:50 **Part II — The Refusal**

In it: The Son, The Father, The Manager, The Step-Daughter

The Son

- What will you not do, and why?
- What are you protecting by refusing?
- What did you see between your parents that you can't unsee?
- What would taking part cost you?

The Father

- Why do you need him to play it?
- What do you feel when your son looks at you?
- What are you willing to do to make him?

The Manager

- What do you do when an actor refuses?
- What do you sense the Son is hiding?

The Step-Daughter

- Why are you sure he can't leave?
- What do you feel watching him squirm?

18:50–19:05 **Part III — The Fountain**

In it: The Son, The Mother, The Step-Daughter, The Manager

The Son

- What did you see at the fountain?
- Why couldn't you move?
- What have you carried since that moment?

The Mother

- What do your empty arms know before anyone says it?
- What do you want to do and can't?
- What is left for you now?

The Step-Daughter

- Why do you run?
- What can you no longer bear to watch?
- Where do you go?

The Manager

- Pretence or reality — what do you walk out believing?
- What have you just been part of?
- Why do you leave?

HOMEWORK

Father, bring your arc with a strong verb per section; Son, learn the fountain story as one breath; Mother, decide the shape of your discovery with the veil never lifting.

BY THE END

We've heard Act Three both ways, found the line between feeling and argument, protected the quiet, and agreed how the staged moments are handled.

The whole play, joined up

Read the play as one connected thing, in words only: relationships across the arc, the layers, the tempo, the nervous comedy, and the safety agreement confirmed.

GOALS FOR THE EVENING

- Follow each relationship across the whole play instead of act by act — where it turns, where it breaks.
- Track the four layers in motion, and mark the moments where “who is more real” flips.
- Find the play's changing tempo — where it races and where it must stop dead.
- Confirm the nervous comedy and every safety agreement, all in words, before we stand up in August.

THE EVENING, HOUR BY HOUR

18:00	Warm-up and recap A short warm-up, then a quick recap of where the three acts left us.
18:15	Relationships across the play Trace each thread across all three acts: the Father explains, the Step-Daughter exposes, the Son refuses, the Mother carries. Where does each one turn?
18:50	The layers Place everyone in their layer again and track the moments where who-is-more-real flips: the casting scene, Madame Pace, the keystone line, the deaths.
19:10	Break (15 min) Rest your voice. Water and food.
19:25	Tempo across the play Walk the changes of pace in order: the company's looseness against the family's drive, the brisk casting scene, the ruptures around the two deaths.
19:55	The nervous comedy Walk the funny beats across the play and agree where each laugh has to turn. "Valentine" stays a wound, not a number.
20:15	Second break (5 min) Short breather. Rest your voice.
20:20	Safety confirmed, in words Walk the full list of contact moments. Each is set safely in August with someone else present. The deaths stay object work; consent can always be withdrawn.
20:50	Go-round and close Everyone names one thing about their whole arc, then we set homework.

HOMEWORK Re-read your whole part against tonight's notes, holding your thread as one line, and keep learning Act One toward off-book on 20 August.

BY THE END

We've held the whole play in one room in words: threads traced, layers placed, tempo and comedy confirmed, and every safety agreement reconfirmed.

The full cue-called read, and hand-off to August

Read the whole play through with the Stage Manager calling cues and the pianist marking tempo, then hand off cleanly to the August staging block.

GOALS FOR THE EVENING

- Run the whole play as one cued read so the company feels its full shape, end to end.
- Make sure each act carries its weight — give Act Two its time — and that the cues land cleanly.
- Leave knowing the through-line, the tempo, and what each person is chasing — ready to be on our feet in August.

THE EVENING, HOUR BY HOUR

18:00	Warm-up and quick recap A short warm-up; pianist ready. Get logistics out of the way now — a quick safety recap and the August calendar — so the read runs unbroken.
18:15	Read Act One with cues Read Act One straight through, seated, with the Stage Manager calling lights and sound and "Valentine" sung or marked. Earn the laugh, then let it curdle.
18:55	Voice rest (10 min) A short rest after the unbroken Act One read, before Act Two, so no stretch of reading runs too long. Water, quiet, no talking needed.
19:05	Read Act Two with cues Read Act Two straight through with full time, the SM calling cues and the pianist marking the Satie and the vamp. Keep the casting scene brisk.
19:45	Break (15 min) Rest your voice. Water and food.
20:00	Read Act Three with cues Read Act Three straight through, the SM calling the cello, the gunshot in real silence, and the Pärt at the end. Leave the silence after the shot alone.
20:35	Notes on tempo and relationships The director gives a few quick, practical notes: where the pace flattened, where a clash needs sharpening, where a thread read clearly.
20:55	Hand-off and thank-you The last table session. The SM confirms the August calendar and the Act One off-book date, and the director thanks the company.

HOMEWORK

Have Act One off-book by 20 August and learn the rest across the summer; arrive ready to be on your feet.

A few traps to avoid

- Skipping the flat read because you want to "get on with it." The flat read is the important one; protect it.
- Treating the over-the-top read as the goal. It's a tool to find the ceiling, not the performance. Run it once, talk it over, then let the size go.
- Directing from page one. Read first, talk second. Ask the room what they found before you offer a reading.
- Letting the comedy win. If the laugh never turns sour, the wounds become jokes. Keep it nervous, never a punchline.
- Over-talking it. Five evenings is tight. When talk stops helping, stop talking and save it for the floor.
- Letting the quiet roles go silent. Ask the Mother, the Son and the Players the same questions as the leads, every night.

This plan is a researched scaffold, not a script for the evenings. Sessions may run longer or shorter inside the 18:00–21:00 window depending on the room; the architecture is what matters — each Thursday lays one course of the wall the August staging block will build on.